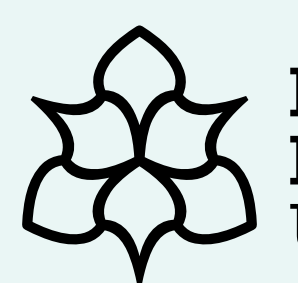
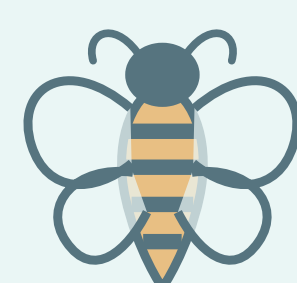




THE CHINA E-COMMERCE EFFECT

China's cross-border e-commerce growth and its links to global industry

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China's e-commerce connects online shopping with international trade. Four views explain how trade has grown, how shoppers' purchase origins changed, why overseas markets differ and how wider services support an order.

THE SERVICES BEHIND AN ORDER

E-commerce is often seen through an app or a website, but a physical order connects sellers, shoppers and several supporting services. Stock must be available, payment has to be arranged, and goods need to reach the buyer. UNCTAD describes platforms offering warehousing, logistics and analytics as well as online transactions. IPC's survey also treats customs and delivery as parts of the shopping experience. This service view helps explain why China's expanding cross-border trade is relevant to firms beyond the shopfront. [3,5]

CONNECT DEMAND WITH FULFILMENT

Our interpretation is that an export opportunity involves both finding customers and organising the services around the order. For example, a seller considering another destination could compare demand evidence with the payment and delivery options available there. The trade chart gives the national scale, the shopper survey shows reported purchase origins and satisfaction, and the regional model highlights differences worth investigating. Using them together helps frame a business question without treating them as interchangeable proof of demand. [1-5]

These photographs illustrate services. They do not document particular Chinese firms or prove a growth trend.



Stock and picking.



Delivery to the buyer.



Online payment.



Order processing.

01

TRADE

02

SHOPPERS

03

MARKETS

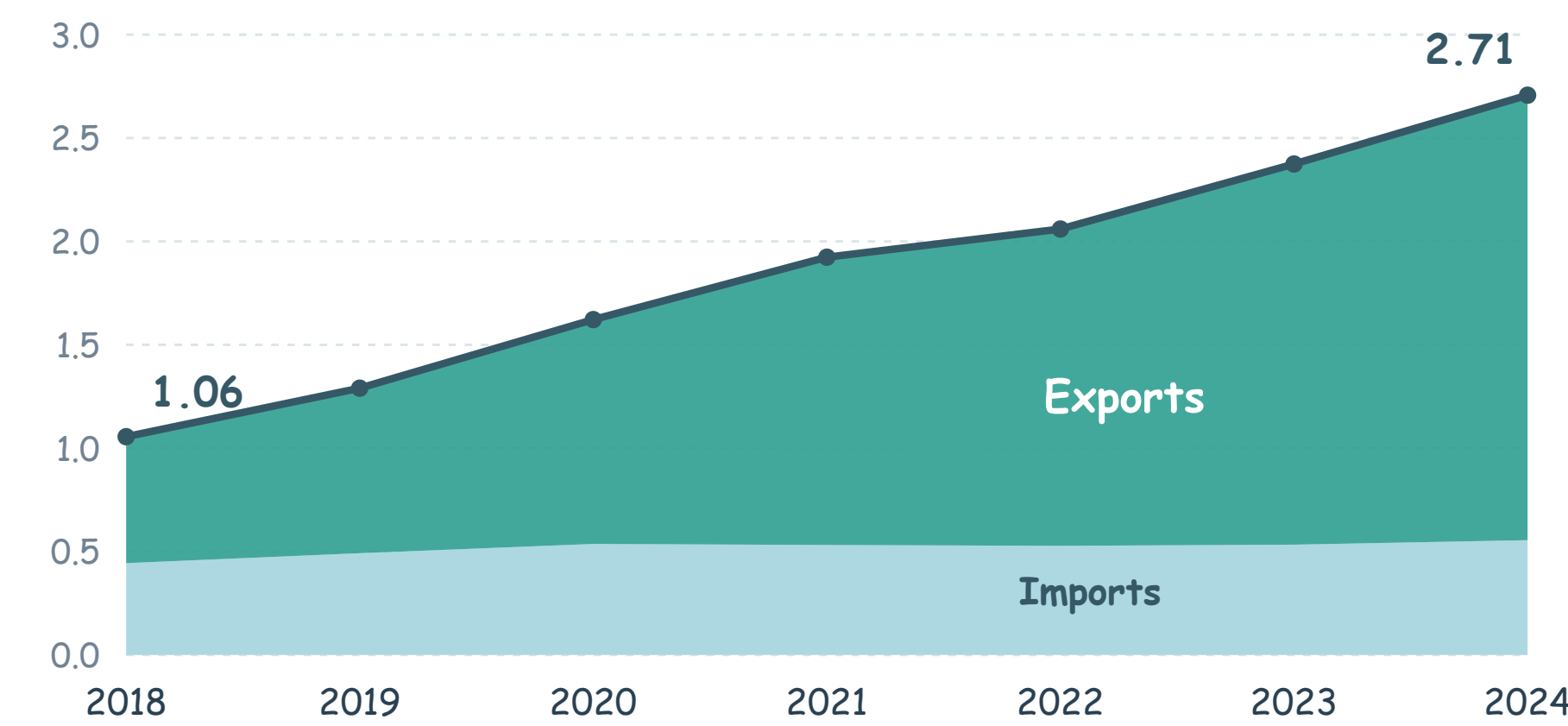
04

SERVICES

01 TRADE GROWTH IS LED BY EXPORTS

Cross-border e-commerce trade

China · 2018-2024 · RMB trillion



A slower growth rate still means expansion

Annual growth was uneven: 25.7% in 2020, 7.1% in 2022, 15.3% in 2023 and 14.0% in 2024. The total kept rising across these years, even when the growth rate slowed. For firms, this distinction matters: slower growth is still expansion, but stock and delivery plans may need to allow for different rates of change. [1]

Exports account for most of the expansion

China's cross-border e-commerce trade rose from RMB 1.06 trillion in 2018 to RMB 2.71 trillion in 2024, up 156.4%. Exports increased by 251.9%, against 25.0% for imports. The gap means that the expansion was concentrated in selling abroad. Imports also grew, so their falling share should not be confused with an absolute fall in purchases from overseas.

What this means for firms

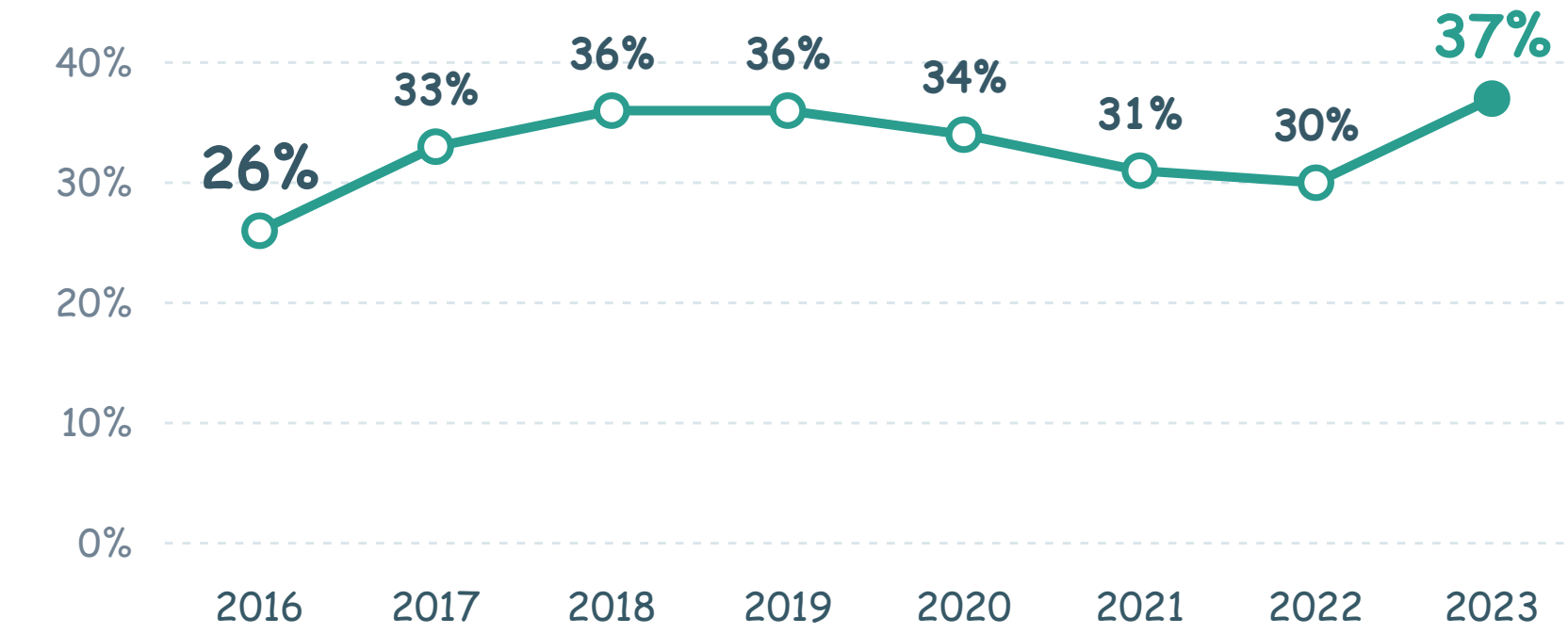
The trade mix links China's growth to overseas customers and the services needed to fulfil their orders. Our interpretation is that firms should consider customer acquisition, payments and delivery together when planning export activity. A growing national total can provide context for that planning, but it does not show demand for an individual product. The figures establish which trade component expanded; they do not isolate the causes.

Source [1]: Ministry of Commerce (2025), Table 11, p. 62; China Customs data. Calculations use published values in RMB 100 million, before conversion to rounded trillion labels. Service interpretation also draws on UNCTAD [5].

02 CHINA-ORIGIN PURCHASE SHARE REBOUNDS TO 37%

Origin of the latest cross-border purchase

Share of surveyed shoppers reporting China (%)



2016-2023: +11 percentage points

The overall increase hides a reversal

China's share was 26% in 2016 and 37% in 2023, an 11-percentage-point increase. However, the endpoint comparison hides a reversal: the share fell from 36% in 2019 to 30% in 2022, before rising by seven points. The 2023 result was only one point above 2019. Sellers therefore have reason to examine the intervening years when assessing demand, rather than extending a smooth upward trend. [2,3]

What does 37% mean?

The percentage measures the reported origin of surveyed frequent cross-border shoppers' latest purchase, rather than the value of all sales. The trend uses 24 countries, while the full 2023 survey covers 32,510 shoppers in 41 countries. This distinction matters when comparing the survey with China's national trade totals: the two sources describe different populations and measures.

A service question for exporters

In the full survey, 71% were very or extremely satisfied with the delivery location, compared with 42% for customs, a 29-point gap. Our interpretation is that an exporter could investigate how buyers receive customs information and how delivery is coordinated. These are practical questions to test in the intended destination; the survey does not establish why satisfaction differs or whether these services caused the purchase-origin trend.

Sources [2-3]: Fan / HKTDC (2024), slide 8; IPC (2024). Trend: 24 countries. Full 2023 survey: 32,510 frequent cross-border shoppers in 41 countries. All eight annual observations are published values.

03 REGIONAL OPPORTUNITIES DIFFER

China and 11 RCEP partner markets

Allocated export proxy / model-implied exports

	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Japan	0.65	0.64	0.54	0.55	0.59	0.57	0.57	0.52	0.47	0.69
New Zealand	0.52	0.57	0.58	0.65	0.62	0.61	0.63	0.61	0.58	0.83
Laos	0.61	1.12	0.81	1.67	0.59	0.41	0.51	0.40	0.36	0.59
South Korea	0.77	0.82	0.72	0.76	0.79	0.74	0.81	0.74	0.69	1.05
Australia	0.77	0.86	0.82	0.98	1.01	1.02	1.08	1.13	0.96	1.32
Singapore	1.05	1.05	0.98	0.94	0.91	0.86	0.97	0.97	0.61	1.03
Malaysia	1.24	1.05	0.96	0.98	1.06	0.99	1.13	1.15	1.12	1.47
Indonesia	1.12	1.33	1.06	1.10	1.07	1.14	1.18	1.00	1.05	1.33
Vietnam	1.27	1.64	1.48	1.54	1.59	1.48	1.65	1.68	1.50	1.74
Thailand	1.33	1.58	1.57	1.77	1.64	1.51	1.54	1.64	1.72	2.45
Philippines	1.23	1.52	1.47	1.92	1.96	1.84	2.00	1.86	1.80	2.24



Categories use 2013-2022 country averages:

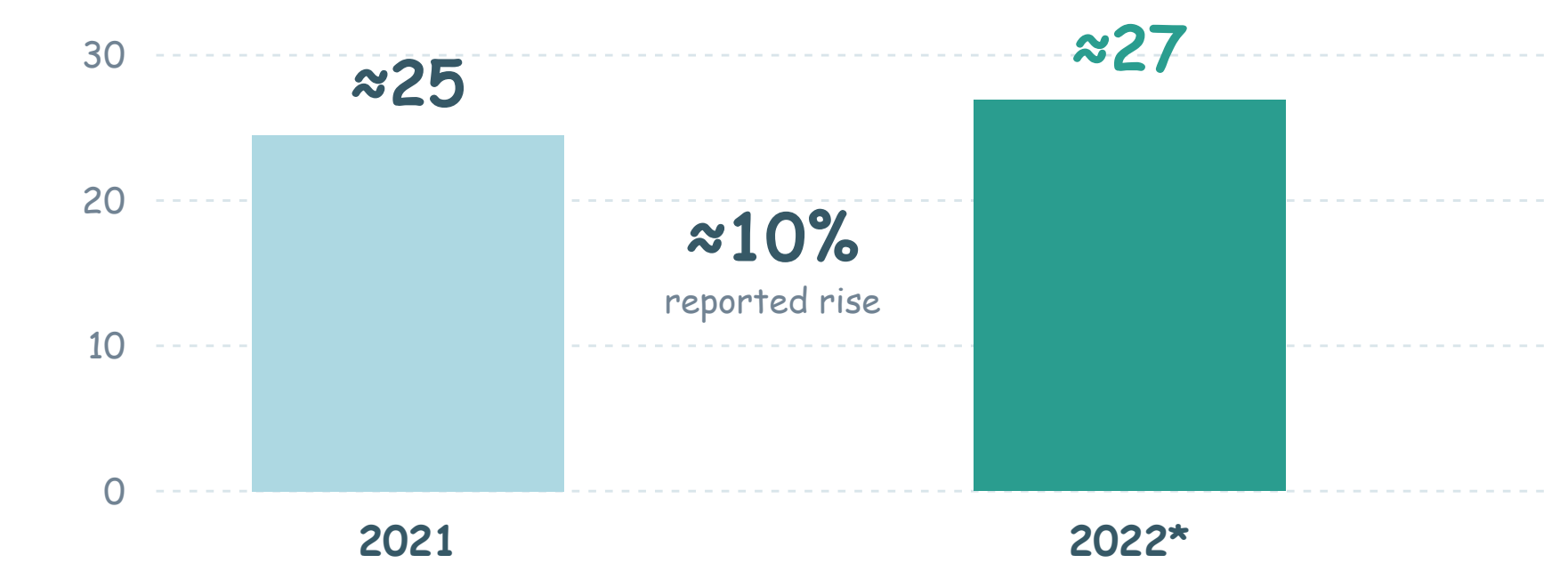
Below 0.8 More unused potential	0.8-1.2 Scope to develop	Above 1.2 New approaches needed
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Source [4]: Zhang and Asraf bin Abdullah (2026), Table 19. Groups use 2013-2022 averages. RCEP: Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. Bilateral exports are allocated proxies, not directly observed flows.

04 E-COMMERCE RELIES ON WIDER SUPPORT SERVICES

Business e-commerce in 43 economies

US\$ trillion · includes domestic and B2B sales



Reading the estimates carefully

Both years include estimated components. The 2022 business-sales total is indicative: about one third of the total is estimated.

37 major online platforms · partial coverage

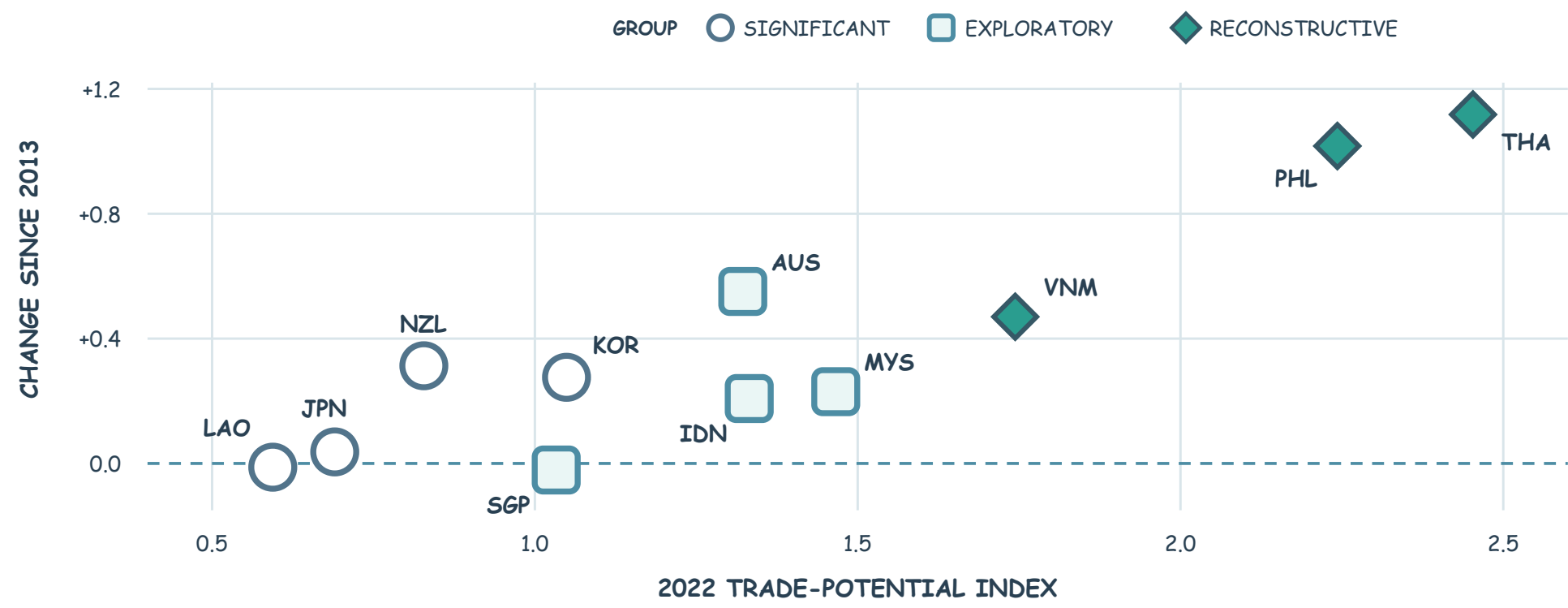


US\$ transaction value · ~55% rise reported by UNCTAD

Source [5]: UNCTAD (2024), pp. 3-4 and 31-32. Rounded figures and source-reported growth rates. The 43-economy total includes domestic and B2B sales; 2022 is indicative. Platform coverage is partial. CC BY 3.0 IGO.

RCEP LEVEL AND CHANGE

2022 proxy/model ratio and change since 2013 · 11 partners



Thailand rose from 1.335 to 2.453; Japan changed from 0.653 to 0.690. The scatter compares ending levels and changes since 2013, while the heatmap shows the intervening years. A high ending ratio and a large increase answer different questions. The movement describes a proxy/model ratio, not a sales growth rate. Source [4].

CONCLUSION

China's cross-border e-commerce trade expanded from 2018 to 2024 mainly through exports. Frequent shoppers in 24 trend countries reported a higher China-origin share of their latest cross-border purchases, while historical model ratios differed among 11 RCEP partners. Our interpretation is that overseas demand should be considered alongside local market conditions and order fulfilment. Platforms, payments, logistics and analytics connect this activity with wider industry. Firms can use these comparisons to investigate customers and service quality, while keeping trade values, survey responses and model estimates distinct.

REFERENCES · Click a source or scan for data and code

[1] Ministry of Commerce (2025). China Digital Trade Development Report 2025, Table 11, p. 62.

[2] Fan / HKTDC (2024). Digital Trade Transformation: Cross-Border E-commerce. Slide 8 (IPC data).

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[3] IPC (2024). Cross-Border E-commerce Shopper Survey 2023: findings and methodology. Release, 11 January 2024.

[4] Zhang and Asraf bin Abdullah (2026). China's cross-border e-commerce exports under RCEP. HSS Communications 13, 941. DOI 10.1057/s41599-026-07267-z.

[5] UNCTAD (2024). Business e-commerce sales and the role of online platforms. Technical Notes on ICT for Development No. 1, pp. 3-4, 31-32.

GITHUB · DATA AND CODE
<https://github.com/hansu650/ice-week1-e-commerce-poster>

